

PROTECTING YOURSELF ONLINE

A Large-Print Take-Home Reference Guide for Older Adults & Families

CincySeniors.org



TIPS FROM HOWIE

"Welcome! Scammers rely on urgency to make you panic. Take a breath, slow down, and keep this reference guide right next to your computer or phone!"



THE GOLDEN RULE

Whenever something feels off, follow this rule before you act:

1. STOP

Don't react to pressure or urgency.

2. VERIFY

Check through a trusted source — never through the message itself.

3. PROTECT

Use strong passwords, MFA, updates, and backups.

 **AI Tip:** AI can help with the analysis. **YOU** make the final decision.

ALWAYS A SCAM — NO EXCEPTIONS

- **Gift Cards / Wire Transfer:** Payment demanded by gift card or wire transfer.
- **Password / Code Requests:** A request for your password or verification code.
- **Remote Access:** Unsolicited request for remote access to your computer.

NEVER SHARE THESE

- **Passwords or verification codes**
- **Full Social Security Number** (last 4 digits only, if needed)
- **Bank or card numbers** by email or text

A legitimate company will never ask for these without a clear, verified reason.

PASSWORDS & ACCOUNTS

- **12+ Characters:** Length matters more than complexity.
- **No Reuse:** Never reuse a password across accounts.
- **Password Manager:** Use one so you only remember one master password.
- **Turn on MFA:** Turn on multi-factor authentication everywhere offered.



OTHER RED FLAGS

- **Urgent, scary language** pushing you to act before you think.
- **Unusual requests** that are uncommon for that sender.
- **Offers of money or a prize** that sound too good to be true.
- **Typos or odd grammar** in a message from a "company".
- **Sender Mismatch:** Display name looks right, but actual address doesn't match.
- **Link Mismatch:** Link destination (hover, don't click) doesn't match.



PROTECT YOUR DEVICES

- **Auto updates:** Turn on automatic updates — install them promptly.
- **Built-in protection:** Keep Windows Defender or Apple protections on.
- **Back up regularly:** Back up to the cloud or an external drive.
- **Lock screen:** Use a lock screen passcode on every device.
- **Find My Device:** Turn on Find My Device now, before you need it.

ID YOUR IDENTITY

- **Shred documents** with account numbers or personal details.
- **Bring in your mail** every day.
- **Review statements:** Review bank and credit card statements regularly.
- **Freeze credit:** Consider freezing credit with Equifax, Experian, TransUnion.

PHONE & WI-FI

- **Unknown numbers:** Don't answer unknown numbers — let them go to voicemail.
- **Text links:** Don't tap links in texts just because they look familiar.
- **Official apps:** Only install apps from official App Store or Google Play.
- **Public Wi-Fi:** Avoid banking on public Wi-Fi — use phone's hotspot instead.

! THE FAMILY-EMERGENCY SCAM

AI can now clone a loved one's voice convincingly. If a caller says *"I'm in trouble, send money"*:

- Do not trust the voice alone.
- Ask for your family's secret word, if you have one.
- Hang up and call the person back on a number you already know.

🔥 IF YOU THINK YOU'VE BEEN SCAMMED

- **STOP conversation:** Do not send any more money or codes.
- **Contact real organization:** Reach out independently.
- **Change passwords:** Start with email, then other accounts.
- **If money was moved:** Call your bank or payment provider immediately.
- **Save details:** Save message, number, and transaction details.

🤖 NEWEST WAYS TO CHECK A MESSAGE OR PHOTO

AI Second Opinion Habit: Screenshot or photograph it, cover private details, and send it to your AI chatbot. Ask what looks suspicious and what to verify independently.

Free purpose-built tools: Norton Genie (www.genie.norton.com) & Bitdefender Scamio (www.scamio.bitdefender.com). New apps built specifically for older adults are appearing too. Stick to well-known companies before trusting an app with your information. Whichever tool you use, get a second opinion, then verify independently!

📞 KEY CONTACTS & REPORTING RESOURCES

FTC Fraud Reporting	reportfraud.ftc.gov 1-877-382-4357
FBI IC3	ic3.gov
Identity Theft	identitytheft.gov
Credit Bureaus	Equifax: 1-888-836-6351 Experian: 1-888-397-3742 TransUnion: 1-800-680-7289

TIPS FROM HOWIE — FINAL REMINDER

 ***"Remember: Technology moves fast, but staying safe comes down to simple habits. Pause, verify independently, and never hesitate to ask for help from someone you trust!"***

CincySeniors.org — Community Technology Safety Guides for Greater Cincinnati.